



LG's self-cleaning TWS

LG Free Tone FN7 TWS comes with UV-C light for self-cleaning ability, and an active noise cancellation. <http://digit.in/nov20-59>



Apple to redesign AirPods

The next version of Apple AirPods and AirPods Pro might shorten, or completely ditch the stem. <http://digit.in/nov20-60>

Realme Buds Wireless Pro

Poorly implemented ANC mars the experience

Augmenting its already prolific presence in the mobile accessories space,

Realme has launched two active noise-cancellation audio devices in India – the Realme Buds Wireless Pro and Realme Buds Air Pro. The latter is the device we are reviewing today, which is the successor to the wildly popular Realme Buds Wireless neckband-style earphones and the company's very first ANC neckband style wireless earphones. Let's find if the earphones live up to the hype.

Build and comfort

The Realme Buds Wireless Pro are anything but dull. The colour scheme is a refreshing change from the monotonous black-coloured wireless headsets. The Realme Buds Wireless Pro comes with a flexible rubber neckband with metal + plastic modules at the end, yellow (or green) rubber cables that lead to the plastic earbuds themselves.

The right weighted module houses all the physical control buttons and the USB Type-C charging port. The rear housings of each bud come equipped with magnets that attach to each other. In a similar vein to the previous Realme Buds Wireless model, the magnetic clamp serves as a power on/off switch for the earphones. While the feature is convenient, it can prove to be slightly aggravating at times, especially if the magnets come loose when you've tucked the earphones into a bag.

Owing to the lightweight nature of the earphones, the buds are naturally pretty comfortable to wear even over extended periods of usage. However, the lack of silicone wings has resulted in a slightly less secure fit overall.

Features

The headlining feature of the Realme Buds Wireless Pro is active noise cancellation. Powered by Realme's S1 chip, the company claims that the buds



are capable of noise reduction of up to 35dB. There's also Transparency Mode available that heightens the ambient noises.

The ANC quality itself was decent, but it drastically changed the sound profile, making it sound brighter and harsh in the higher frequencies. Moreover, the ANC also caused an abysmal amount of distortion in the bass response and the lows. We found that toggling off Volume Enhancer in the Realme Link app makes the distortion became slightly more manageable.

Other features include 119ms low latency Gaming Mode, LDAC codec support, Google Fast Pair, IPX4 rating, and app support.

Sound quality

As we mentioned above, turning on ANC pretty much ruins the sound quality of the earphones, so for our audio tests, we listened to music on streaming apps and our own collection of high-res audio with ANC turned off. The earphones sport 13.6mm Bass Boost drivers with LDAC, AAC and SBC codec support. With ANC turned off, the Realme Buds Wireless Pro provide quite a commendable sound quality, with a pleasant warm sound profile that has punchy yet controlled

bass response, commanding lows, clear and detailed mids, and decent highs.

We also found that the soundstage was pretty wide and the imaging was decent. Also, the performance was noticeable better on LDAC than on AAC or SBC, with more detail packed into the mids with LDAC turned on.

Battery life and microphone

Housing a 160mAh battery, the Realme Buds Wireless Pro has a battery life of a whopping 22 hours with ANC turned on, and 16 hours with ANC turned off. The earphones also come with Fast Charge support where 5 minutes of charge nets you about 100 minutes of playtime. We found that with

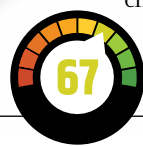
mixed ANC usage and the volume levels at about 50-60 percent, we managed to squeeze out 19 and a half hours of playtime.

Moving on to the microphone quality, it is decent and got a mixed bag of reactions from people we called. Some said that the sound was clear while others complained that it sounded thin and muffled.

Bottomline

Priced competitively at ₹3,999, the earbuds offer users a plethora of premium features. However, the otherwise great pair of earphones are marred by the poor implementation of ANC which causes tons of distortion in the sound. Overall, we wouldn't be comfortable recommending these earphones unless you plan on avoiding ANC completely.

—Dhriti Datta



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SPECIFICATIONS

BLUETOOTH VERSION: 5.0 | COLOUR: Disco Green / Party Yellow | Effective range: 10m (in an obstacle-free environment) | NOISE CANCELLATION: Active Noise Cancellation (ANC) & Environmental Noise Cancellation (ENC) | WATER RESISTANCE RATING: IPX4 | BATTERY LIFE: 16hrs with ANC on; 22hrs with ANC off | CHARGE TIME: 1.5hrs full charge; 5mins charge for 100 mins playback | SOUND DRIVER SIZE: 13.6mm | AUDIO CODEC: LDAC, AAC, SBC

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